thamesview

Your magazine from Gallions | gallionsha.co.uk | October 2009



Repairs and maintenance

Our service explained

Scam busters

Protect yourself from fraud and scams

Fabulous family events

Keep busy this autumn

Gallions Residents Board

Election results are in

Thamesview October 2009

Kidsview

Gallions Housing Association

Inside: Gallions Disability Forum, Furniture Bank update, Leaseholder section.

tw magazine

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Autumn's here!

In this issue of Thamesview we have lots of information about our repairs and maintenance service, an update on the Furniture Bank and three pages of great events!

Don't miss our latest tips on avoiding scams and swindles, created to help you stay one step in front of the fraudsters. There is plenty more advice on our website at www.gallionsha.co.uk too.

With this edition of Thamesview you will have received our Residents Annual Review 2008/09, which contains our key performance data for the last year. Whether you want to know the total number of Gallions homes, more about resident involvement or how much we have invested in our properties you will find it here.

Make sure you look out for the yellow reader idea symbol in the following pages as this shows where we have included information because of your feedback.

Gallions Housing Association

FSC Mixed Sources

GRB GALLIONS RESIDENTS' BOARD APPROVED

Furniture Bank grand opening!



If you need more storage or want to update your home make sure you visit the brand new Furniture Bank opening in Tavy Bridge later this month. The Furniture Bank has been set up by Gallions and the Gallions Residents Board to provide our residents with access to much needed good quality furniture.

The Furniture Bank will open on Wednesday 28th October between 10am and 2pm in the old betting shop at Tavy Bridge. There will be great a range of furniture pieces available to take away on the day; all you need to do is bring proof of your tenancy and proof of ID (preferably photo ID). The service is offered on a 'first come, first served' basis and customers will be able to choose one item only. Home delivery can't be provided so you should arrange getting items home yourself.

If you would like to donate your unwanted, good quality furniture call Team Gallions on 0800 83 84 81 and we will arrange collection.

Don't dump on your neighbourhood

Our residents tell us that they're unhappy with the way people get rid of their rubbish in the area, particularly larger items such as sofas, mattresses and furniture. Leaving bulky items in the street is fly tipping, which is a criminal offence.

This summer we trialled a new appointment-based service so residents could call us to arrange for us to pick up their bulky waste. As the pilot was so popular, we will continue offering this free service, for up to three bulky items, for residents in high rise blocks. Other residents should contact their local council for collection or take their items directly to the tip.

For further information, or to arrange a collection, contact 0800 83 84 81.

Thank you to Mrs Ibrahim, Mr Finnegan and Mrs Mitchell for telling us that more should be done about rubbish in our neighbourhoods. We have more ideas we'll be trialling soon aimed at improving our services and the environment. We will publish the latest updates in Thamesview over the coming months.





Be scam aware

At Gallions we want to help you protect yourself from potential scams and fraud. This is our guide to common scams and how to deal with them:

Doorstep criminals

Not all visiting sales people are scammers but you should always carefully consider buying goods or services at your door. Doorstep callers offering most goods or services over £35.00 should provide you with a seven day cancellation period in writing.

Phishing

Phishing usually takes the form of an email or pop up message that appears to be from a reputable organisation, often a bank or auction site, which asks you to update your account information. Never reply or click on a link to give your personal or financial details.

Lotteries, sweepstakes and competitions

If it sounds too good to be true it probably is. If you receive a letter or phone call telling you that you've won a prize in a competition or lottery you haven't entered be very sceptical. Never send money to release your prize and make sure you understand the call charges associated with 090 telephone numbers.

Working from home

These scammers often advertise in local papers or on posters in the area. They advertise paid work from home, some exaggerating how much you could earn or asking for money up front for materials or information. Always think carefully before giving money in advance and aim to work for reputable companies.

For more advice about scams contact Consumer Direct on 08454 04 05 06 or visit www.consumerdirect.gov.uk.

This is your Council. It is vital that you have your say in how things are run.

Don't lose your voice
Register to vote



Complete your Household Electoral Registration form that has been delivered to your home. Electoral canvassers will be calling at every property between 23rd September and 23rd October that has not returned a form. The canvasser will have a reminder household registration form for your property and will be able to help you complete this.

Forthcoming elections

Elections for Greenwich Councillors will be held on Thursday 6th May 2010. The parliamentary general election could be called at any time, but it has to take place no later than Thursday 3rd June 2010.

Why register?

It is important that you are registered to enable you to vote in local and national elections. It may also have an impact if you wish to obtain credit or a mortgage if you are not registered as an elector.

For further advice please contact us below.

Electoral Office 020 8921 5183
elect@greenwich.gov.uk

Greenwich Council
Promoting equality and quality of life for all

SPOTLIGHT ON

Bexley Thameside Gingerbread Group

Gingerbread is the national support service for lone parents and their families. The group is made up of both men and women, with children always welcome at meetings. The group gets together in Erith every other Friday evening to chat, share parenting tips and to get information. The group is always looking for new members to join in with the fun and especially encourages anyone happy to promote the group and get involved with fundraising to get in touch.

Contact Sarah on 0208 306 2685 or Julia on 01322 556 696 if you would like to join in with the next meeting. Visit www.gingerbread.org.uk or call 0800 018 5026 for advice and information especially for single mums and dads.

Every issue we will be focusing on one group or service in the area. If you'd like us to shine the spotlight on what you do then please get in touch (details on the welcome page). Contact us too if you want to list your group or provide us with updates.

For little ones (under 5)

Greenmead Children's Centre, Lime Row (off Yarnton Way), telephone Tel: 020 8320 1618

Goose-e-ganders parent and toddler group, Broadwater Village Hall, telephone 07958 640645

Toddles, Manor Close Community Hall, Manor Close. Term time, Monday to Friday 9.30am until 11.30am and 12.30pm until 2.30pm.

Toddles with Tavy Bridge Pre-School, Senior Citizens Hall, Tavy Bridge, telephone 07950 853481

Lighthouse Parent and Toddler Group, Emmanuel Church Hall, telephone 0208 312 4700, Wednesdays and Fridays 1.30pm until 3pm.

Young Foundations Pre-School, Emmanuel Church Hall, telephone 0208 312 4700, Monday until Friday 9.30am until 12 noon.

Toy Library, Linton Mead Primary School, Central Way, telephone 0208 310 1902, Friday 9am until 11am, term time only, for under 5s.

Discovery Children's Centre, Battery Road, telephone 0208 855 4320, Monday, Wednesday and Thursday 9am until 4pm and Tuesday and Friday 9am until 1.30pm.

Editor's note: Thamesview does not endorse or recommend any clubs or groups listed. We aim to provide accurate and up to date information but cannot be held responsible for any misleading or inaccurate information supplied to us.

For bigger ones

The cAve climbing wall, Arch 3, Harrow Manor Way, telephone 0208 320 4494, www.trust-thamesmeadcave.co.uk, Monday to Friday 4pm until 7pm and weekends 1.30pm until 5.30pm, everyone aged 4+.

Fun Club, Glimpsing Green, telephone 0208 311 6777, Saturday mornings, for under 11s with a disability.

JMF Support Group, Jubilee Hall, Lytton Strachey Path, telephone 0208 310 5885, Saturday 1pm until 3pm

Rainbows, Church of the Cross, Lensbury Way, telephone 0208 310 2419, for 5 to 7 year olds.

Rainbows, Abbey Wood Community Centre, 4 Knee Hill, telephone 0208 311 2239, Wednesday 4.45pm until 6pm, for 5 to 7 year olds

Brownies and Guides, Church of the Cross, Lensbury Way, telephone 0208 310 2419, for girls aged 7+.

Brownies, Greenmead Community Centre, telephone 07960 815229, Every Tuesday from 6pm, Girls age 7 to 10.

New Acres Library, Tavy Bridge, telephone 0208 311 5291, for all young people, from babies to teenagers.

Hawksmoor Youth Club, Bentham Road, telephone 0208 312 4022

Heronsgate Youth Club, Whinchat Road, 07950 612826

Performing Arts

Dynamix, Bexley Business Academy, Yarnton Way, telephone 07796 450093, for ages 6 to 20

Theatre Street, Broadwater Village Hall, Gooseander Way, telephone 01322 441977, www.theatrestreet.com, tots to adults

Youth Advisory Project, 12 Tavy Bridge, telephone 0208 311 5111, for 16 to 24 year olds

Young at Heart

Monday Club Bingo, Jubilee Community Centre, Lytton Strachey Path off Titmuss Avenue, telephone 0208 311 5707, Monday 2pm until 4pm

Over 50s Bingo Club, Greenmead Community Hall, Lime Row, telephone 0208 310 0240, Monday and Thursday 7pm until 9pm

Rendezvous Club, Evenlode House, Coralline Walk, telephone 0208 310 7437, Wednesday, for the over 55s

The Atrium Community Centre, Teeswater Court, telephone 0800 83 84 81, 7 days a week. Fun and free over 50s keep fit classes run Wednesday 4.30pm until 5.30pm.

Just for Fun!



Take some time out to enjoy our brainteasers. Remember you only have to complete the wordsearch for the chance to win a prize.

1 Winter quiz

a) Who wrote A Christmas Carol? _____

b) What happened to the River Thames in the winter of 1683-84? _____

c) Finish the title of this Christmas film – It's a _____ life.

d) What day is the winter solstice in the UK this year? _____

e) Who sang Merry Xmas Everybody? _____

2 Through the years

Can you match the year with the event?

1963, 1977, 1981, 1989

The year the Berlin wall came down _____

Elvis Presley died _____

Prince Charles and Princess Diana got married _____

The Beatles reached number one in the UK singles chart for the first time _____

Answers:
1. Charles Dickens, It froze, wonderful, 21 December, Slade
2. 1989, 1977, 1981, 1963

3 Halloween wordsearch

It's Halloween at the end of the month so we have hidden six spooky words in this wordsearch. Find them all and you could win a £25 Morrsions voucher.

Pumpkin **Trick** **Ghost**
Bats **Treat** **Costume**

C	O	R	O	L	K	R	H	E	N	F	H	I	R	Y
H	O	O	S	C	W	T	H	E	T	L	E	T	R	O
D	U	S	I	T	S	N	E	E	E	U	L	P	N	O
T	H	R	T	O	R	E	N	I	R	D	E	O	A	S
C	T	O	H	U	I	E	R	S	N	S	A	R	S	T
N	T	G	M	P	M	R	A	P	A	A	N	T	O	R
I	I	D	B	U	R	E	D	T	A	I	M	O	O	S
E	O	S	I	M	I	O	T	S	N	T	I	H	O	I
H	W	S	S	P	M	C	G	G	E	I	S	S	E	U
I	S	T	H	K	O	A	W	O	O	C	T	T	H	D
I	A	P	T	I	T	R	S	E	R	R	E	R	S	A
B	P	O	D	N	H	D	M	N	R	H	D	T	E	N
U	O	D	W	E	G	V	R	R	E	Y	A	P	T	S
O	D	A	N	E	S	N	R	R	I	U	E	T	H	T
E	E	H	U	A	G	T	T	N	S	S	E	E	I	U

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Anita Dagger, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost SE6691, London, SE2 9BR or drop it into our reception by 20 November 2009. The winner will be selected at random.

Name: _____

Address: _____

Telephone: _____

Email: _____

Congratulations to Jennifer Gocool of Binsey Walk who was selected as the winner of our last wordsearch competition.

Events Calendar

There are exciting things happening in your area.



October 2009

Black History Month begins
1 October

Orienteering for Beginners at Danson Park
17 October

Join the Dartford Orienteering Club (DFOK) for a fun morning of orienteering for all the family. Learn some great map reading and navigation skills as well as getting some gentle exercise.

Need more details? The activities will take place 11am - 12pm and cost £2 for adults, £1 for children and £1 equipment hire. Register on the day near the car park at Danson Stables. Contact www.dfok.co.uk or call 01689 600030 for more information.

Diwali (Sikh/Hindu)
17 October

Christmas Craft Market
24 October

Start your Christmas shopping early at Saint Martin's Church, Erith Road, Barnehurst. With lots of unique and interesting gift ideas, beautiful homemade crafts, mince pies and mulled wine you will definitely get into the festive spirit!

Need more details? Contact 01322 559200 to find out more.

Apple Day at Woodlands Farm Trust
25 October

All the family is invited to the Woodlands Farm Trust Apple Day this autumn. Go along and meet the animals, relax in the café, pick up quality local produce or get involved in craft activities and games. Entry is free but donations are welcome.

Need more details? The Woodlands Farm Trust is located at 331 Shooters Hill, Welling and near to Oxleas Wood. Call 020 8319 8900 or visit www.thewoodlandsfarmtrust.org for more information.

Half Term for Greenwich and Bexley Schools
26 - 30 October

Events Calendar



There are exciting things happening in your area.

November 2009

St Mary's Christmas Bazaar
6 November

Make a date in your diary for this Christmas bazaar and you could enjoy crafts, games, face painting, competitions, Father Christmas, refreshments and much much more. The fun will take place at St Mary's Church Hall and grounds, Marina Drive, Welling between 7pm and 9pm.

Need more details? Admission is 20p. Email bazaar@stmarythevirgin.net or call 020 8303 7777 for further information.

Danson Park Family Fireworks Spectacular
7 November

Celebrate fireworks night in style at this year's Danson Park Spectacular! There will be a traditional funfair, great food and family entertainment available.

Need more details? The event will run from 6pm - 9pm and tickets cost between £2 and £5. This event is in aid of local charitable causes. Visit www.dansonparkfireworks.co.uk or call 0800 840 2181 for further information.

Remembrance Sunday
8 November

Get ready for Christmas
14 - 15 November

If you are looking for a special gift this year visit Hall Place Christmas Fair for a range of unique, traditional and modern presents for all the family. The event will take place at Hall Place and Gardens, Bourne Road, Bexley between 10am and 4pm.

Need more details? Visit www.bexley.gov.uk or 020 8303 7777 for full details.

Eid al-Adha (Muslim)
27 November

Santas on Broadway
29 November

Imagine the scene at the Broadway, Bexleyheath... 1000s of Santas, a Christmas market, entertainers, live bands and Christmas lights... certainly something not to be missed. You can be a part of this magical experience and help support the Greenwich and Bexley Hospice, all you need to do is register and don your santa suit!

Need more details? Sign up for the parade online at www.cottagehospice.org.uk or call 0208 319 9230. Registration costs £10 for adults and £5 for children aged 5-15, which includes santa suit hire.

Events Calendar

There are exciting things happening in your area.

December 2009

Christmas in Trafalgar Square
3 December

Don't miss the fantastic Christmas tree lighting ceremony at Trafalgar Square this December. Each year since 1947 a Christmas tree has been given to the people of London from the people of Norway as a symbol of gratitude. The tree is usually a Norwegian spruce over 20 metres high so if you haven't been to this magical ceremony before check it out!

Need more details? Visit www.london.gov.uk or call 020 7983 4100 for more information.

Light up a Life
11 December

Visit St Pauls Church, Bentham Road for a special service this December. A Christmas tree will be lit in the memory of loved ones and dedications can be made, all in support of the Greenwich and Bexley Hospice.

Need more details? Visit www.cottagehospice.org.uk or call 020 8312 2244 for more information.

Christmas Carols
12 December

Enjoy a really different Christmas Carol concert this December at the National Trust Red House in Bexleyheath. There will be traditional mulled wine, cider and seasonal treats. The Red House will be dressed for three ages of Christmas - the Sixties, the Victorian Era and Medieval Times.

Need more details? Call 0208 304 9878 or visit www.nationaltrust.org.uk.

Hanukkah (Jewish)
12 - 19 December

Christmas break for Greenwich and Bexley schools
21 December - 1 January

Christmas Day (Christian)
25 December

Raising standards

Gallions is working with Keep Britain Tidy to improve the environmental quality in our properties and neighbourhoods. We have recently completed the first phase of internal surveys, which helped us assess the standards of cleanliness inside our properties, including communal windows, floors, lighting and bin rooms.

We surveyed a sample of areas inside our mini, linear and tower blocks between May and August and we have now evaluated the data collected. Overall the results were positive, but we have already identified some areas where changes need to be made in our cleaning practices. We will be carrying out regular assessments to make sure that things are improving but we need you to work with us to keep communal areas clean and tidy.

For more information contact the communications team on 0800 83 84 81 or email communications@gallionsha.co.uk.



A great new group

The new Gallions Disability Forum met for the first time in August. Their purpose is to represent the issues of those with disabilities, raise awareness and share information. At their first meeting the Disability Forum looked at the responses from the accessing our services questionnaire which was sent out with the last issue of Thamesview.

Gallions provides a range of services for our residents who have a disability or another barrier which can prove difficult when accessing services, including:

- **Adapted toilets in the reception of our office in Harrow Manor Way**
- **Fire safety speech and visual aids in our reception**
- **Hearing loops in our reception**
- **Home visits by Gallions wardens**
- **Leaflets stored at a lower level in our reception**
- **Lower level reception desk in our reception**
- **Printed word made available in other formats**
- **Sign language interpreter**
- **Stair lift at our office**
- **Translation service**
- **Type Talk**

The Disability Forum expressed concerns over access to some public areas, in particular for those who had problems with mobility, and agreed to make this their first area for research and improvement. For more information or to join the group please contact Sue Asquith on 0800 83 84 81 or by email sasquith@gallionsha.co.uk.

Make sure you're covered!

Gallions is responsible for taking out buildings insurance for the structure of our properties. However, as a tenant you should make sure you have household contents insurance to protect your belongings if something happens in your home. If you don't have insurance you will have to pay the full cost to replace items that are damaged or lost.

Contents insurance will often cover you for flood damage, fire damage and burglary. Gallions will not pay to replace your personal possessions like electrical goods, soft furnishings and jewellery in most cases.

Gallions is working with the National Housing Federation and Jardine Lloyd Thompson insurance to offer low cost contents insurance for our residents. Cover starts from just 82p a week for over 60s and £1.12 a week for others. You can pay in cash or by direct debit at fortnightly, monthly or yearly intervals. To find out more contact us on 0800 83 84 81 or visit our office at Harrow Manor Way to pick up a form. You can also get contents insurance from a number of independent companies.

Stay on track this Christmas



We understand that you might have extra pressure on your budget at this time of year, but it is really important that you stay up to date with your rent and other priority bills (like council tax, gas, electricity and water). If you don't keep on top of your payments you could risk eviction, having your utility supply cut off or a fine. This winter we will be visiting our residents in arrears to give advice, make payment arrangements or book appointments with our Welfare Benefits or Revenue Officers. If we visit you make sure you talk to us - we can help if you are struggling to manage your money. For more information about budgeting, benefits or rent payment methods contact us anytime on 0800 83 84 81.

At Gallions we celebrate the diversity of our neighbourhoods. We offer a comprehensive translation service to make communicating with us easy. If you would like this issue of Thamesview magazine translated into your own language please contact us. You can call 0800 83 84 81, email translations@gallionsha.co.uk or visit our office at Harrow Manorway, Thamesmead, London, SE2 9XH. We can translate documents into any language and have audio, large print and Braille options available.

ਗੈਲੀਅਨਜ਼ ਵਿਚ ਅਸੀਂ ਆਪਣੇ ਇਲਾਕਿਆਂ ਵਿਚਲੇ ਵਖਰੇਵਿਆਂ ਦੀ ਕਦਰ ਕਰਦੇ ਹਾਂ। ਸਾਡੇ ਨਾਲ ਗੱਲ ਬਾਤ ਕਰਨਾ ਸੌਖਾ ਬਣਾਉਣ ਲਈ ਅਸੀਂ ਤੁਹਾਨੂੰ ਥਾਮਜ਼ਿਊ ਮੈਗਜ਼ੀਨ ਦਾ ਇਹ ਅੰਕ ਜੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਆਪਣੇ ਘਰ ਦੀ ਜਾਂ ਸਾਡੇ ਮਕਸ਼ੀਅਰ ਨੂੰ ਵੇਚਣ ਬਾਰੇ ਇਸ ਪੜਦੇ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਆਪਣੀ ਬੋਲੀ ਵਿਚ ਕਰਵਾਉਣਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾਂ ਬਿਲਕਲ ਕਰਕੇ ਸਾਡੇ ਨਾਲ ਸੰਪਰਕ ਕਰੋ। ਤੁਸੀਂ ਸਾਨੂੰ ਨੰਬਰ 0800 83 84 81 'ਤੇ ਫੋਨ ਕਰ ਸਕਦੇ ਹੋ, ਜਾਂ ਇਸ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਈਮੇਲ ਭੇਜ ਸਕਦੇ ਹੋ translations@gallionsha.co.uk, ਜਾਂ ਅੱਗੇ ਦੱਸੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਸਾਡੇ ਦਫ਼ਤਰ ਵਿਚ ਚੁਪ ਆ ਸਕਦੇ ਹੋ - Harrow Manorway, Thamesmead, London, SE2 9XH. ਅਸੀਂ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ਾਂ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਕਿਸੇ ਵੀ ਬੋਲੀ ਵਿਚ ਕਰ ਸਕਦੇ ਹਾਂ, ਅਤੇ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਸੁਣਨ ਵਾਲੀ ਟੇਪ 'ਤੇ, ਵੱਡੇ ਅੱਖਰਾਂ ਵਿਚ ਅਤੇ ਬ੍ਰੇਲ ਵਿਚ ਵੀ ਦੇ ਸਕਦੇ ਹਾਂ।

Chúng tôi vui mừng vì sự đa dạng về dân cư ở Gallions. Chúng tôi cung cấp dịch vụ dịch thuật toàn diện để tạo điều kiện dễ dàng cho quí vị liên lạc với chúng tôi. Nếu quí vị muốn dịch số này của cuốn Tạp chí Thamesview sang ngôn ngữ của quí vị, hãy liên hệ với chúng tôi. Quí vị có thể gọi điện thoại theo số 0800 83 84 81, gửi thư điện tử theo địa chỉ translations@gallionsha.co.uk hoặc đến văn phòng của chúng tôi tại Harrow Manorway, Thamesmead, London, SE2 9XH. Chúng tôi có thể dịch các tài liệu sang bất kỳ ngôn ngữ nào và luôn sẵn có các lựa chọn khác như ghi âm, in khổ lớn và chữ nổi.

格莱昂斯房屋協會 (Gallions) 頌揚我們鄰舍地區的多元化面貌。我們提供全面的翻譯服務，以便他們與我們進行溝通。如欲要求我們把本期的 Thamesview 雜誌翻譯成繁體中文 (廣東話)，請告訴我們。你可以致電 0800 83 84 81、發送電郵到 translations@gallionsha.co.uk，或親臨我們位於 Harrow Manorway, Thamesmead, London, SE2 9XH 的辦事處提出要求。我們可以將文件翻譯成任何語文，也備有語音、特大字體和凸字版本，以供選擇。

Punjabi ◯ **Vietnamese** ◯ **Chinese** ◯
(Please tick one)

Name .....

Address .....

Return to: Anita Dagger, Translation Requests, Gallions Housing Association Harrow Mannor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Our repairs and maintenance service explained

We understand that you want things to work well in your home. As your landlord we offer a comprehensive repairs and maintenance service, in conjunction with our partners and contractors.

Did you know?

Repairs

1. When you call to report a repair we will tell you immediately if the repair is your responsibility or ours
2. For the majority of repairs you will be offered an appointment for the operative to attend within a two hour time slot, for example between the hours of 2pm and 4pm
3. All of our operatives will show you their identification when they visit to make a repair

Planned maintenance/Home improvements

1. We publish the details of our annual planned maintenance/home improvement programme (including updating kitchens, bathrooms, windows and more) in our reception at Harrow Manor Way and on our website at the beginning of April each year
2. Where possible we will give you a choice of worktops, doors, cabinets and paint colour if we are updating your kitchen or bathroom
3. You will have the opportunity to view some of these options in a local 'show room'
4. Where the maintenance takes place in a communal area we will consult with all residents in the block; for example about colours, and advise you of the majority choice

Our planned maintenance progress

So far this financial year (since April 2009) we have carried out many improvements in your homes as part of our planned maintenance/home improvement programme.



This includes:

* 232 new kitchens
* 131 new bathrooms
* 215 re-wires
* 160 window renewals

We have completed work in the following areas:

* Shire Court
* Teeswater Court
* Waterfield Close
* Maran Way
* Austen Close
* Binsey Walk
* Fieldfare Road
* Poplar Place
* Garganey Walk

We are committed to continuing to improve your home and each year Gallions invests in improving our properties. If your home is due to be updated we will write to you in advance to let you know. If possible you will be given choices about colours and materials used in the works.

For more information about our repairs and maintenance service please contact our Asset Management Team on 0800 83 84 81.

Latest news for Leaseholders

Improve or move?

In the current economic climate, lots of people are choosing to improve rather than move. If that's you, then there are some things you might want to consider.

Alterations:

Leases may differ slightly on wording but in essence written permission is always required for any structural alterations and in some cases may be required for smaller interior alterations. You should always ensure that you get permission before making any alterations as it can be difficult to obtain permission afterwards.

Remortgaging:

If you are a shared owner, Gallions approved your mortgage when you bought your home. If you want to change your mortgage, you need to ask our approval. We won't refuse this as long as the new mortgage is for the same amount as your old one and is on the same terms. This means you cannot borrow any extra money on your mortgage or take out a loan using your home as security.

In certain circumstances, for example for home repairs, we can allow further borrowing. Please contact the Leasehold Team on 0800 83 84 81 for more information.

If you bought your home from Gallions under the Right to Buy or Right to Acquire initiatives we have a legal charge on your property for five years from the purchase date. During that time remortgages or loans are only allowed for home improvements. You will need to send us written estimates for the work you are having done. Outside the five-year period, you must also ask us in writing for permission.

You will be expected to clear any debts with us before we can give permission.

Problems in obtaining a mortgage:

If you live in Southmere, Lesnes, Parkview and parts of the Moorings, your home is of concrete construction. Gallions is aware that, in general, lenders have considerable reservation about lending on concrete houses because some types (elsewhere) have exhibited signs of decay. This is not the case in Thamesmead. The leasehold team can supply you with a factsheet which may allay the lenders fears.

What it's worth?:

In order to agree to extra borrowing your lender will want to value your home. Valuers look at property sales in the recent past in order to assess the value of a similar property in the present day, so they are always looking back. As the market is now, with a historically low number of house purchases, finding evidence of comparable sales is difficult. This means the valuer has to keep a close eye on the housing market activity asking estate agents for information about properties that have been sold in the area and watching local auctions. They then combine all of this information and come up with a value.

Location location location:

On top of this, popularity of the road, age, construction and external appearance of your home are important considerations. A good reason for keeping your home well maintained and smartly presented.

Leasehold Surgeries

We run surgeries for homeowners at our offices in Harrow Manor Way on the first Thursday of every month between 10am and 12pm. If you would like to make an appointment please call into reception, telephone our free phone number 0800 83 84 81 or contact us by email - leaseholdmanagement@gallionsha.co.uk

Rent and Service charge queries

If you would like to talk to us about your rent or service charge account, just call us on 0800 83 84 81 to make an appointment with Janine Boyle. She can meet with you on a Tuesday between 10am and 3pm.

Pets

Shared ownership leases do not allow dogs. The only time we may agree an exception is if there is direct access to your own private garden from your home and you have a guide dog or disability assistance dog.

Gallions Website

The team are in the process of updating and improving the information provided on the homeowner pages of Gallions website – check online at www.gallionsha.co.uk for the latest updates.

Notice Board



Contribution Day 2009



Contribution Day 2009

Gallions gives something back

This summer the whole Gallions team got together to give something back to the community. During Contribution Day in July Gallions staff worked on seven different community projects in the area to help improve the local environment and life in our neighbourhoods. From canal clearing in the Moorings and gardening at Buckwheat and Shire Courts to building animal habitats at Gallions Nature Centre and log clearing at the Greenwich and Bexley hospice our staff really got stuck into improving your neighbourhood. It was a fantastic day and we hope that the results of our projects will last for many months to come. We are planning to run a similar initiative next year so look out for details in the summer.

GRB election results

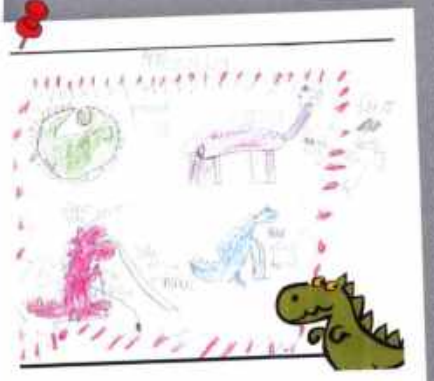
This June the Gallions Residents Board (GRB) carried out their annual election and the following residents were elected: A Lin Sin, Adrian Gogerly, Michael Alejo, Claudette Lawrence, Deborah Frimpong, Anthony Whiting and Fatomi Sewje. Congratulations to all of our members. The GRB is made up of elected volunteers and is open to tenants, charge-payers and leaseholders. The group works together to represent all residents and to improve services at Gallions. For more information contact Helen Chambers, GRB Officer on 0800 83 84 81 or email hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk.

Celebrities visit Thamesmead

This summer Orange RockCorps, the initiative that encourages young people to volunteer in return for an exclusive concert ticket, visited Thamesmead. Gallions worked with 94 Orange RockCorps volunteers, Thames 21 and Thamesmere Leisure Centre to clear rubbish, build nesting rafts for birds and paint benches and gates around the leisure centre. Pop act FrankMusik and TV presenter Miquita Oliver even came along to help with the project! Full details can be found online at www.orangerockcorps.co.uk.

Competition winners announced

In the last edition of Thamesview we told you that Gallions was successful in securing funding from Playbuilders, in partnership with the London Borough of Bexley. The money will be used to refurbish three of Thamesmead's play parks, with Glimpsing Green Park receiving the first makeover. As Thamesmead is rich with pre-historic fossils, a dinosaur theme was chosen for the new look. Children from both Northwood and Parkway primary schools took part in a drawing competition to show how the new park could look. Congratulations to our winners! First prize of a fabulous art set went to Anthony Day with runners up Abdullah Gula and Shubba receiving art goodies.



Next steps for the TSA

The TSA (Tenant Services Authority) is the new regulator for social housing. Earlier this year the TSA ran the National Conversation initiative to find out what social housing tenants thought of their homes and landlord.

This feedback will go towards developing new standards to improve services for tenants and inform the future of social housing. The feedback reports are available to view online at www.nationalconversation.co.uk or by calling 0845 230 7000.
The third and final stage of the National Conversation is due to start this November, when the TSA publishes its revised proposals for landlord standards. All tenants will be able to comment on these standards so make sure you get involved!

Careers at Gallions

Details of our current employment opportunities are publicised on our website and at our reception desk. Please get in touch on 0800 83 84 81 if you are interested in a career with us.

Complaints and contacts

Gallions aims to provide a first class service to all its residents. However, if you are unhappy with the service you have received there is a policy in place to help you make a complaint. A guide is available on our website.

Complaints@gallionsha.co.uk

www.gallionsha.co.uk

0800 83 84 81

Thamesview publication details

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Contents Insurance from 82p a week!



Whether you live in a flat or a house you should have adequate contents insurance to cover your possessions against damage or loss.

Read our article on page 11 for more details or call us on 0800 83 84 81.

Gallions Housing Association